

IN THE EAST, A Fragile Peace

Two LTTE defectors help the Government showcase the province but the battle for power is beginning

Few defectors from the LTTE have escaped Vellupillai Prabhakaran's wrath. Yet it is a sign of the LTTE chief's weakening hold that two of his lieutenants, Karuna, his former Eastern commander, and Pillayan, from the political wing, have not only defied his writ but collaborating with the Sri Lankan Government, pushed out the Tigers from the East. Now Pillayan, a former child soldier of the LTTE, is the first chief minister of the Eastern Province and Karuna has been made a member of Parliament. It is part of President Mahinda Rajapakse's policy of showcasing the East as an example of the way forward. Rajapakse even boasts that "we have given them pardon without

CHANGING STRIPES: Karuna (left) and Pillayan

the provincial elections with the newly-created TMVP allying with Rajapakse's United People's Freedom Alliance (UPFA). Together they won 22 of the 37 seats in the council. Rajapakse said he had to expend tremendous political capital to make Pillayan the chief minister. Once ensconced in the chief minister's chair, Pillayan expressed his unhappiness over his lack of power to deal with issues such as law and order, education and land as the devolution of authority from the Centre to the Provincial Councils was far from satisfactory. For the Sri Lankan Government, the East, despite being freed of the LTTE's control, remains a troubled zone. There is lawlessness in the region with the LTTE indulging in robbery and even murders.

The army divisions stationed in Trincomalee and Batticaloa are there to make sure the LTTE does not make a comeback, and also play a major role in maintaining law and order. In Trincomalee, Brigadier Janaka Walgama of the 22nd Division, says, "What we have now is a fragile peace."

Last week in Pillayan's heavily guarded house in Batticaloa, Karuna, who had come to address a meeting, made it a point to emphasise that there were no differences between them. Karuna projects himself as the real leader. Pillayan though content to play second fiddle in conversations quietly asserts his position and his views. Karuna claims that he quit the LTTE when he realised that Prabhakaran was only interested in battle and was unwilling to work towards a settlement. Karuna says Prabhakaran had turned a terrorist and hadn't realised that Eelam had become "an unattainable goal". He is confident of surviving Prabhakaran's repeated attempts to bump him off. Karuna is positioning himself to take over as leader of the Tamils if Prabhakaran is defeated. He has lost much of credibility among Tamils though for crossing over to the other side. Karuna remains unafraid of Prabhakaran and says, "The whole world knows that Prabhakaran is a dummy. After all I have survived him." Famous last words?

by Raj Chengappa in Batticaloa

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AP PHOTO/GEMUNU AMARASINGHE



even producing them before a magistrate". Rumours are rife though that there is a rift between Karuna (real name V. Muralitharan) and Pillayan (S. Santhirakanthan) over sharing of power in the East. Karuna was far senior in the LTTE hierarchy than Pillayan till last year when he went off to London leaving Pillayan in charge of their newly-formed political party, the Tamil Makkal Viduthalai Puligal (TMVP). He was arrested by the British police for having a forged passport and it was Colombo that bailed him out, but not before he spent several months in jail.

Pillayan in the meanwhile fought

Karuna wants to take over as the leader of the Tamils after Prabhakaran; Pillayan may be quieter, but is not afraid to speak out.